



Slop / University

What the Beep Misses

A university that counts.



Come and count with us

Every day, somewhere near you, a small machine decides something matters enough to check, and something else doesn't. A scanner beeps or it doesn't. A light turns green or it doesn't. A form asks you to confirm and moves on regardless. Slop University exists because someone has to notice what these ordinary checks actually catch, and what they only appear to.

Across the School of Emergent Priorities and the School of Continuous Improvement, our researchers spend less time in laboratories than in the places where a check gets performed for real: a hardware-store swap cage, a real-estate shopfront window, a school pickup lane in the middle of the afternoon. The instrument is rarely the point. What it displaces, what it misses, and what a busy person does once it has spoken — that is the University's ongoing subject.

This is not a claim that checking is pointless. It is a standing interest in the gap between a system built to notice and the noticing it actually does. Come and see what we've counted, and what has quietly gone uncounted alongside it.



The short version

A sample of what the University’s everyday research programme looks like in practice.



Everyday sites

From hardware-store swap cages to school pickup lanes, our fieldwork happens where the checking already happens, not in a lab built to resemble it.



Public reach

Findings return to the neighbourhoods, clubs, and shopfronts that hosted the fieldwork, not just to the journals that cite it.



What gets missed

A standing programme of work asking what an automated check quietly waves through, and who ends up deciding anyway.

Where ideas count

Everyday instruments

Long before an indicator earns a dashboard, it starts as a small decision: check this, not that. The School of Continuous Improvement’s Indicator Commons catalogues these ordinary instruments as they enter daily life — a swap-cage scanner at a hardware store, a permit checked at a school gate, a seating chart balanced by algorithm rather than habit. Few of these checks were designed to be studied; most were designed to be quick. The School’s contribution is patience: watching what a fast check actually confirms, once it has been running long enough for someone to notice it, or not.



An instrument survives less by working than by nobody getting around to asking whether it still does.

— Dr Renke Sabel, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Indicator Commons, School of Continuous Improvement

Where the record lives

A disclosure only works if someone reads it, and a great deal of the School of Emergent Priorities' fieldwork starts exactly there: at the shopfront window, the property card, the printed code nobody quite stops for. The School's Strategic Drift Survey measures a related distance at institutional scale — between what a policy says and what a routine actually does — and its researchers keep finding the same gap in miniature, on ordinary high streets, whenever a disclosure is technically present and practically unread.



A disclosure that nobody reads is still a disclosure. It just isn't doing the job we usually assume disclosures do.

— Dr Runa Adegoke, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Strategic Drift Survey,
School of Emergent Priorities

Signals worth a second look

Not every signal arrives from a machine. A report, a consultation, a submissions period are checks too — built to register something before a decision proceeds. Lecturer Solveig Adeyemi follows these civic instruments the way our engineers follow a scanner: does the record actually change what happens next, or does it mostly confirm what was already settled before the first submission arrived? The University's own community-facing work, from public lectures to open data walks, is built with that question in view rather than around it.



A report that reaches a decision-maker unchanged wasn't really read on the way. It was just delivered.

— Dr Solveig Adeyemi, Lecturer, School of Continuous Improvement

Ideas in print

Three recent findings from across the University's Schools, each starting from an ordinary check and following it further than most people bother to.

- **Same Call, Different Camera** — a season-long look at a hardware chain's photo-based safety check, and how closely it tracks a trained eye. [doi:10.5555/slop.b7j0ib](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.b7j0ib)
- **Scanned Rarely, Compared Almost Never** — a shopfront disclosure code, and an honest account of how often anyone actually taps through. [doi:10.5555/slop.xzcpwq](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.xzcpwq)
- **Skipped the Line, Not the Wait** — a paid pickup lane, and where the time it saves actually goes. [doi:10.5555/slop.1bx2n3](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.1bx2n3)

Meet the researchers

Dr Fenna Okoro, Senior Lecturer and Convenor of the Horizon Register (School of Emergent Priorities), maintains the University's rolling account of which everyday checks are next in line for a proper look.

Dr Bram Ntuli, Lecturer and Convenor of Improvement Grand Rounds (School of Continuous Improvement), runs the standing case-review sessions where findings like these get argued over in front of a room before they go to print.

Be part of it

Slop University's research happens in ordinary places, which means there is usually one near you already. If a check in your street, your workplace, or your child's school has ever seemed to say more than it actually knows, we would like to hear about it — and, in time, to come and look properly.

Public lectures, open data walks, and community briefings run across both Schools throughout the year, and visitors are welcome at all of them. Researchers and current students are glad to talk through the work in person, in plain terms, without the instrument doing the talking for them.

Come and see what we've found, and tell us what we've missed. Details for every event, and the full record of what the University has published so far, are kept at slop.university.



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